clarified that the nuclear power pack filled with plutonium-238 would remain in the Himalayas until it deteriorated, becoming a radioactive menace that could leak into the Himalayan snow and infiltrate the Indian river system through the headwaters of the Ganges.

An Indian intelligence report said that the CIA had started up Nanda Devi after the autumn of 1965, but razor-sharp winds and un-seasonal storms delayed them and then winter's approach forced them to retreat short of the top. Intending to return in spring to finish the mission, they found a sheltered cranny on the southern lee of the mountain and stashed the special pack. In all, fourteen American climbers signed on with the CIA though ultimately only nine were sent to India. They were joined by four of India's best mountaineers from the 1962 Indian Everest expedition. In addition, the CIA had the unofficial cooperation of its Indian counterpart. An American undercover agent on the Indian intelligence payroll co-opted Indian intelligence, setting up the arrangement on an informal basis to preserve the CIA's absolute authority over the project. The CIA had demanded that Indian intelligence, which relied heavily on the US spy expertise, keep the affair secret from Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and other top-ranking officials of the government that then ruled India. The CIA was concerned that the Gandhi government might veto the project as needlessly provocative, since India's relations with China were then at a flash point. The CIA did give the then US president, Lyndon Johnson, a general outline of the project, but the agency also asked him not to notify the Gandhi government, a circumstance that became another reason for the US cover up.

An MEA telex message further claimed that the author of the article, Howard Kohn, held a press conference in New York and